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Tweet's song raises eyebrows, but doesn't break new ground

▸ TWEET
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so buttery brown and tantalizing." So what if she decided to douse her own fire?

"We're all so desensitized at this point," says Shani Saxon, music editor at Vibe magazine. "I'm surprised anyone thinks that a song about masturbation would be a big deal. I would expect the majority of people to be like, 'Whatever.'"

That's been the reaction of some "Hot 97" and WMJN-FM "Jam'n 94.5" listeners to Tweet's debut, which hit No. 1 on Billboard's R&B singles chart and is now a "buzzworthy" video on MTV. The 30-year-old protege of rapper and producer Missy Elliott will release her first CD, "Southern Hummingbird," on April 2.

"We've been playing it for a while," says Clark. "Not one call."

When asked about it, members of the Boston Blacks Online Web community were similarly nonchalant: "She's exploring herself," writes Lisa Bynoe, 24, a Dorchester resident. "There's nothing degrading about that."

This country has come a long way since M. Joycelyn Elders got booted from the surgeon general job in 1994 for suggesting that self-gratification be discussed in school sex-education classes. At that time, Elders says, "We never talked about it. You couldn't even say the word."

The floodgates opened around the time of the Elders uproar. Now people discuss the "M" word and buy how-to guides such as "The Joy of Self-Pleasuring: Why Feel Guilty About Feeling Good?"

"There are teachers saying, 'It's all right. You're not going to go blind,'" says Elders. "It's not as mystified as it used to be."

Musicians have contributed to the cause by singing praises to the art of loving oneself. In 1996, TLC member T-Boz caused a stir with her sultry single "Touch Myself." Green Day explored the subject in 1994's "Welcome to Paradise." Before that, the Divinyls' "I Touch Myself" and Cyndi Lauper's "She Bop" titillated the eyes and ears of MTV viewers.

A new generation of artists have made masturbation seem almost mundane. Last year's hip-hop hit "Oochie Wally" was filled with disturbingly pornographic lyrics. And let's just say the R&B quartet 112's latest song, "Peaches & Cream," is not an ode to fruit and milk.

PHOTO/RUVEN AFANADOR

Listeners' reactions to Tweet's song range from "disgusting" to "whatever."

"There are so many things that are rapped about and sung about that are far worse than masturbation," says the anonymous writer of a column in the popular e-mail newsletter Electronic Urban Report, who recently wrote about the controversy over "Oops (Oh My)."

Those sentiments do not take into account the feelings of people offended by the song. Cardwell argues that the Bible simply does not permit the sexual act. Not so, says Elders, who believes that perception remains because "we still have ministers who preach that."

The hoopla over "Oops (Oh My)" shrouds the fact that the lyrics are so vague, listeners must figure out what Tweet means when she sings: *"This body felt just like mine, I got worried / I looked over to my left, a reflection of myself / That's when I couldn't catch my breath."* Even Tweet doesn't say her single is about doing *that* deed. In an interview with Honey magazine, she connected it to her former discomfort with her dark skin, saying it's "about self-appreciation. Coming home and seeing myself in the mirror and noticing that I'm beautiful."

However you interpret it, at a time when lyrics seem to offer nothing but complaints about trifling men and money-hungry women, Tweet's message of self-love provides relief to weary ears.

"It's a different topic for a change," says 34-year-old Natasha Mason of Mattapan. "It's, in a sense, women taking back the power instead of being objects in other people's songs and videos."

Concert update

Peter Serkin will play a solo piano recital April 12 at 8 p.m. in Jordan Hall for the FleetBoston Celebrity Series. The performance replaces the previously announced joint recital with violinist Pamela Frank, who is still out with a recurring hand injury. Serkin's program includes Beethoven's "Diabelli" Variations, Schoenberg's Op. 11 Piano Pieces, and two works by Oliver Knussen.

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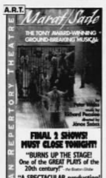

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